

So why Inkscape or even vector graphics?

Vector graphics are inherently very high-quality graphics. While a bitmap is defined by rows and columns of pixels, a vector image is defined by straight, and if needed curved, lines. Thus, almost any kind of image can be represented in its true shape by vector graphics: an image, after all, is composed of lines and curves. On the other hand, a pixel will cause some distortion at the edges of a shape, especially when magnified. Thus vector graphics is used when high-quality, distortion-free images are desired.

Inkscape does not quite have all the options that a professional graphics designer might want, but still has plenty of options for an enthusiast to get hooked on to image editing. It can import all common image types as .png or other vector-based formats.

You can either edit an existing image or create your own using the Pencil, Pen and Calligraphy tools. Standard shapes can be used, such as rectangles, ellipses, stars, polygons, spirals, etc. You can even introduce text and make changes to it. Moving, Scaling, and rotating can be done free-hand or by specifying values. There are a lot of options you can check out by simple trial and error. It is easy to be captivated by this program if you are the artistic kind! By the way, the maximum zoom supported is 128x—not that you'll need it, of course!

We will very quickly run you through the very basic operations of Inkscape and leave you to do the rest. The screen looks more forthcoming and friendly than does The GIMP's. You can open an existing file or create one yourself afresh. When you open Inkscape, a blank work area is available, or you can click **File > New**, and select from the various size formats available.

You have standard ready shapes to start your work on—rectangles, stars, ellipses, and circles, from which more combinations can be developed. On the canvas, just click and drag using the appropriate shape tool to create the shapes. Each shape tool